

Hybrid AI norm

As we look towards 2026, smartphones will increasingly become part of a hybrid AI world, where some AI happens on the device, some in the cloud, and some across both. The real acceleration will come from on-device intelligence because of latency, privacy, context and from delivering more performance per watt, which is what makes advanced AI usable all day on a



phone. We're moving toward a future of personal AI, where an assistant sits in the middle and your phone, earbuds, or glasses become ways to access it. As models become more multimodal and more capable, the smartphone will evolve from being just an app platform into a truly intelligent, context-aware companion at the centre of a personal AI ecosystem..

—SUMIT SONAL, HEAD OF MARKETING, QUALCOMM INDIA

Richer, immersive reality

The next phase of the industry's evolution will be defined by immersive experiences and how consumers connect with technology across lifestyles - at cinema, at home. We are seeing broader adoption of Dolby Vision for example across smartphones, enabling richer colours, greater brightness, and contrast, while ensuring content is optimised for each device. At the same time, Dolby Atmos is expanding immersive sound experiences across everyday lifestyles. In India, Dolby Atmos is enabling lifelike, immersive in-car entertainment that enhances every journey.

—SAMEER SETH, DIRECTOR, MARKETING - INDIA, DOLBY LABORATORIES



Thoughtful devices

2026 will be defined by thoughtful device experiences as the smartphone industry evolves beyond raw specifications. Longer software support, improved durability, and robust after-sales support will be critical. Refined build quality, durable hardware, and strong day-to-day performance, particularly battery longevity and reliability rather than on-paper numbers, will matter more than ever. We will continue to dive deeper into the categories we already operate in, with cutting-edge technology and more options for consumers, including larger devices in categories such as phones and TVs.

—SANDEEP SARMA, ASSOCIATE DIRECTOR, MARKETING & PR, XIAOMI INDIA



Wireless audio shines

By 2026, technology will be defined by how seamlessly high-fidelity sound, AI intelligence, and user-centric design converge to create truly immersive experiences. Audio will evolve from a focus on hardware features to creating personalized, intelligent, and emotionally engaging sound experiences. One of the most significant shifts will be the rise of the wireless

audiophile, where uncompromised sound quality is no longer tied to fixed, wired environments but is available wherever listeners choose to engage. High-resolution wireless playback will remove the final barrier between studio sound and everyday listening, allowing consumers to experience music as it was intended. Spatial and immersive formats will reshape how music is consumed.

—SAAHIL KUMAR, SENNHEISER CONSUMER HEARING BUSINESS, INDIA (SONOVA CONSUMER HEARING, INDIA)

